

A Comparative Approach of the Portrayal of the Cultural Identity in Toni Morrison's *Song of Solomon* and in Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart*

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ABSTRACT

This article proposes a comparative study of the portrayal of cultural identity in Toni Morrison's *Song of Solomon* (1977) and Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart* (1958). Both works, emblematic of African-American and African literature respectively, deploy the resources of oral tradition, ancestral myth, and linguistic symbolism to construct and assert a cultural identity long subjugated by colonial and post-colonial forces. Through sociological, historical, and linguistic approaches, this study highlights the manner in which the two authors use oral tradition and proverbs as fundamental identity markers. Morrison, in a quest for roots in an African-American context, exploits the flying myth to restore a fragmented memory and build bridges between Africa and the diaspora. Achebe, for his part, in an anti-colonial perspective, deploys the Igbo proverb as a vehicle of collective wisdom and resistance against Western cultural hegemony. This comparative analysis reveals how these two writers, despite their different geographical and historical contexts, share the same literary and ideological project: to restore cultural dignity and reaffirm the richness of African and African-American identities.

Keywords: Cultural identity, oral tradition, proverb, Toni Morrison, Chinua Achebe, African literature, post-colonialism, literary comparison.

1. INTRODUCTION

Literature constitutes one of the most powerful vectors of cultural identity affirmation. In the context of post-colonial studies, the works of Toni Morrison and Chinua Achebe occupy a central place insofar as they address, each in their own way, the question of the construction and preservation of cultural identities marginalized or denied by Western colonialism.

Morrison, in *Song of Solomon* (1977), and Achebe, in *Things Fall Apart* (1958), use narrative strategies that draw on the oral traditions, myths, and linguistic practices of their respective communities to restore a sense of belonging and cultural pride. The question that guides this study is: In what ways do these two authors use literary tools to portray and assert cultural identity? The hypothesis is that both authors, despite their different contexts, share an analogous literary project aimed at rehabilitating marginalized cultures by exploiting the resources of oral tradition.

2. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This study is based on three complementary theoretical approaches:

The sociological approach examines how social structures influence the construction of literary identity. The historical approach contextualizes the works in the African-American and African post-colonial experiences. The linguistic approach analyzes the use of proverbs, myths, and oral traditions as markers of identity.

The concept of cultural identity, understood as the set of cultural characteristics that define a group and distinguish it from others, is central to our analysis. Stuart Hall's work on cultural identity in the diaspora provides a particularly

relevant framework for understanding Morrison's approach, while Ngugi wa Thiong'o's reflections on language and decolonization illuminate Achebe's project.

Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'third space' is equally pertinent, as it allows us to understand how both authors negotiate between the cultural heritage of their communities and the dominant Western culture, creating hybrid spaces where new forms of cultural identity emerge.

3. ORAL TRADITION AS IDENTITY MARKER

3.1 In Toni Morrison's Song of Solomon

In *Song of Solomon*, Morrison draws extensively on African-American oral tradition to construct the identity of Milkman Dead, the novel's protagonist. The flying myth, inherited from African tradition, serves as a central metaphor for the recovery of cultural roots. The song of Solomon itself, transmitted orally through generations, embodies the collective memory of the African-American community and its connections with the African continent.

Morrison uses proverbs and folk wisdom to anchor her narrative in an authentic cultural tradition. The character Pilate, with her songs and stories, represents the living repository of this oral memory. Morrison writes: 'If you surrendered to the air, you could ride it.' This metaphor of flight encapsulates the novel's central theme: the recovery of cultural identity through reconnection with ancestral heritage.

3.2 In Chinua Achebe's Things Fall Apart

Achebe integrates Igbo oral tradition into the very structure of his novel. The proverbs that punctuate the narrative serve as both cultural markers and narrative devices. As Achebe himself states: 'Among the Igbo the art of conversation is regarded very highly, and proverbs are the palm-oil with which words are eaten.'

These proverbs are not mere stylistic ornaments; they embody the collective wisdom of the Igbo people and assert the richness and sophistication of their culture against the backdrop of colonial denigration. Achebe consciously employs this strategy to counter Western representations of Africa as a continent without history or culture. The very use of English to describe Igbo cultural practices represents a subversive act: appropriating the colonizer's language to celebrate colonized cultures.

4. COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS: IDENTITY CONSTRUCTION STRATEGIES

Despite the geographical and historical distance separating them, Morrison and Achebe share fundamental literary strategies in their construction of cultural identity:

- a) Recovery of Memory: Both authors use narrative as an instrument for recovering collective memory. Morrison reconstructs the fragmentary memory of the African-American diaspora through Milkman's journey to the South, while Achebe preserves the memory of a pre-colonial Igbo society threatened by colonization through the story of Okonkwo.
- b) Language as Resistance: For both authors, language itself becomes a site of resistance. Morrison's use of African-American vernacular and Achebe's integration of Igbo linguistic structures challenge the hegemony of standard English and affirm the validity of subaltern cultures.
- c) Mythical Dimension: Both novels draw on myth as a source of cultural legitimacy. The flying myth in *Song of Solomon* and the creation myths referenced in *Things Fall Apart* ground the characters' identities in a cosmological

framework that transcends colonial history.

d) Community and Belonging: Identity in both works is fundamentally communal. Neither Morrison nor Achebe conceives of identity in purely individual terms; rather, individual identity is always embedded in and shaped by community bonds, traditions, and shared histories.

e) The Role of Women: An important but often overlooked aspect of both novels is the role of women as guardians of cultural memory. Pilate in *Song of Solomon* and the female characters in *Things Fall Apart* serve as repositories of cultural knowledge and oral tradition, suggesting that cultural identity is transmitted and preserved primarily through female lineages.

5. THE DIALECTIC OF TRADITION AND MODERNITY

Both Morrison and Achebe grapple with the tension between tradition and modernity, a central concern of post-colonial literature. In *Things Fall Apart*, this tension is dramatized through the figure of Okonkwo, whose rigid adherence to traditional values leads to his tragic downfall in the face of colonial change. Yet Achebe does not romanticize tradition; he acknowledges its contradictions while asserting its value.

Similarly, Morrison's *Song of Solomon* explores the tension between the modern urban world in which Milkman grows up and the ancestral rural world of his family's origins. Milkman's journey South represents not a regression but a dialectical synthesis: he incorporates the wisdom of the past without rejecting the present.

This dialectical approach distinguishes both authors from simpler forms of cultural nationalism. Their works do not call for a return to an idealized pre-colonial past; rather, they advocate for a creative engagement with cultural heritage that can sustain communities in the post-colonial present.

6. CONCLUSION

This comparative study of Toni Morrison's *Song of Solomon* and Chinua Achebe's *Things Fall Apart* reveals a convergence of literary projects aimed at rehabilitating and affirming marginalized cultural identities. Through their deployment of oral tradition, proverbs, myths, and linguistic strategies, both authors create works that serve simultaneously as aesthetic achievements and acts of cultural resistance.

Morrison and Achebe, from their respective positions in the African-American and African literary traditions, demonstrate that literature can be a powerful instrument for the construction and preservation of cultural identity. Their works invite us to reconsider the relationships between literature, memory, and identity, and to recognize the richness of cultural traditions long marginalized by Western hegemony.

Ultimately, what unites these two canonical works is their insistence on the humanity and dignity of their characters and communities - a humanity that colonial discourse sought to deny. In asserting this humanity through the medium of literary art, Morrison and Achebe make a lasting contribution not only to their respective national literatures but to world literature as a whole.

This study opens perspectives for future research on the connections between African and African-American literary traditions, suggesting that these two bodies of literature, despite their apparent separation, are linked by deep cultural and thematic ties that deserve further exploration.

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